DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

How Can a Perfect God Create an Imperfect World?

Daat Tevunot §26-29

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §26-29 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 19 September 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

This class completes the first section of the book. So far: God is the ultimate good and wants to give the ultimate good. He cannot create other gods, so He creates beings who can connect to Him. To make that good truly theirs, He creates imperfect beings who must perfect themselves, and the essence of everything is connecting to Hashem in the world to come. The Sekhel now has one more thing to add (§25).

God held Himself back (§26)

The Sekhel says: know that God could certainly have created man and all of creation in complete perfection. More than that, given His perfection, He should have. A perfect Creator would be expected to make perfect creatures, without our frailties and base desires. But once He decided in His wisdom that we should perfect ourselves, He had to create us imperfect. So He withheld His perfection and His great goodness and made us the way He wanted, not the way His power alone would have produced.

The Ramhal adds a Gemara: one of God's names is Shaddai, "He who said to His world, dai, enough." The heavens were stretching out, growing bigger and bigger, and He told them to stop. The Rabbi drew out the message. God could have made infinitely more creatures than the 7.5 billion people alive today, and every creature, human, animal and every wonder of the universe, could have been greater. Had He created according to the Creator's capacity there would be no end. Instead He created according to what His creatures need, in the right measure for the purpose of human beings. His infinite creativity had to be held back.

Simsum: the basis of Kabbalah

"This paragraph is the basis of all Kabbalah," the Rabbi said. The opening lessons of the Ari teach simsum, contraction, before any talk of the sefirot (Keter, Hokhmah and so on). He was careful to say this must be discussed with caution: - Before the world was created there was only the Or Ein Sof, the endless and infinite light of Hashem, filling everything. - If God is everywhere, how can there be anything else? So He withdrew, and created what the Ari calls

the halal hapanui, an empty space. - Within that space He placed the universe and the sefirot. Running through all of it is a light from Hashem, but not Hashem Himself, because if He Himself filled the universe there could be no universe. - The same applies to each individual: a perfect Creator would make perfect creatures, so to create us He had to hold back.

At certain times, such as in the sukkah on Sukkot, we are told we can tap into that light. It is always there, but it is not everything. "It's the only way you can explain our existence," he said, "because otherwise how on earth can a perfect God create an imperfect universe?"

Questions from the group

- **Clockwork:** a participant recalled being told that God made people able to sin because there is no point being emperor of a clockwork kingdom. The Rabbi said that is only half the answer. Hashem could have made beings simply basking in His goodness. The full answer is that good which you did not earn is (a) embarrassing, living off something you did not work for, and (b) not godly: Hashem is good intrinsically, so our good must also be our own. To choose good we need imperfection, so He needs an imperfect world, and that is possible only through simsum.
- **Was this the first world?** Another participant noted that, according to the Midrash, God created worlds and destroyed them before this one, and the Kabbalah says many more times. It is hard for the human mind to grasp.
- **Is the world really imperfect?** Yes. Not only people: nature has hurricanes and tsunamis too. The Rabbi linked this to the discussion of whether night is a creation or simply the withdrawal of day. Theologically the second makes more sense: darkness comes from withholding, not from God making something imperfect. "You can be as provocative as you want. That's the purpose of this journey."

The Neshamah agrees (§27)

The Neshamah says this is certainly necessary. We believe God is perfect and all-able, with no limit to His power. So any imperfection, boundary or limitation we see is not because that is what He is, but because that is how He wanted us to exist.

Children born with disabilities

A participant asked how a child born with serious disabilities can reach perfection. The Rabbi answered in stages: - Perfection is relative. People have different capacities and each is judged by his own. As before: the Torah says no prophet will be like Moshe, yet the Rambam says anyone can be like Moshe. Moshe may have gone from 80 to 180; we can reach our own 100. As long as a person has some ability to improve, reaching his top is his perfection and his cleaving in the world to come. - The harder case is a child with no ability to improve at all. Here he offered two possibilities: gilgul, or that it is for the people around the child and how they respond. He said he is not keen on the second, as it is insensitive. In any case, as said at the start of the book, the details of why this person and not that one are beyond us; we only have the general principles.

The summary of the section (§28-29)

The Sekhel sums up: God withheld His creative power and made human beings not as Himself but as He wanted, imperfect, so that they would perfect themselves. That perfection will be their merit because they toiled for it, and in this way God can bestow perfect good. In §29 the Sekhel turns to the next principle: yihud Hashem, the oneness of God, which the Rabbi said comes at the perfect time, just before Yom Kippur. Much of the first third of the book echoes Derech Hashem; new material is coming. The next class would be on Wednesday instead of Thursday.

Summary

- God could and, given His perfection, should have created a perfect world; He held back so that we could perfect ourselves.
- Shaddai, "who said to His world dai," expresses this: He created in the measure His creatures need, not the measure of His power.
- This is simsum, the foundation of the Ari's Kabbalah: God withdrew to leave a space in which an imperfect universe can exist.
- Imperfection in the world reflects God's will for us, not a flaw in Him; each person's perfection is measured by his own capacity.
- The section on the purpose of creation ends; next comes yihud Hashem.

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